caught by a painting in the window.... I went in and enquired and it was Husain alright? The price was Rs 350, which was nearly half my monthly salary. But I had fallen for it and couldn't wait to take it home and share my enthusiasm with my wife. The painting was 'Holi', which has been widely reproduced and it has been on my walls for several years.... To lose it now would be to lose a part of me."

There was no looking back after that. Khanna was part of the famed PAG, which made history by rooting modern art in India. His memory, which is as acute as ever, takes him back to the Partition days.

In a poignant work made by him, 'Refugee Train Late 16 hrs' (oil on canvas, 1947), a group of men and women wait in suspense for the train which would take them across the border. For Khanna, the Partition remains as vividly alive as if it just happened. "It was during the crucial months...we trooped out in two cars and came straight to Shimla where the Education Department [his father was deputy director of education with the government] was then going to be founded.... The evening in Lahore would be penetrated by howling cries as area after area would be set afire and it still haunts me and holds me immobile."

Once the family left Lahore during the Partition, Khanna was to work as a banker in Mumbai while he continued to paint, a profession which he devoted himself to solely from 1961. The artist is known not only for his modernist concerns with the language of art but also for his acute vision which highlights the plight of the underdog. The machinations of power and corruption which impoverished many is focused upon in his 'Game' series, the paintings on Christ as well as those of the Mahabharata of the later years. His humanistic concerns drove him to make works like 'Rear View', which express the plight of migrant labourers huddled in trucks like bundles of objects or the 'Bandwallahs', who in their ragged costumes and brassy instruments are a poignant reminder, despite their flashy gear, of the plight of the underprivileged. Khanna has also made murals, the most memorable of which is for the lobby of the ITC Maurya hotel in Delhi and relays the great procession, an epic play of life and death.

More than anything else, Khanna's views, debates and recollections have left many a young artist and art lover enriched. He is what one might call a fortunate man. He sits in his drawing room, which is also now his studio, as he is no longer able to walk down to his basement. His wife Renu, who is 97, keeps him company and they share their views on art and life. His two daughters and son visit him frequently. According to Karan Khanna, his son, the children value their meetings with him. "He keeps us all happy. He is like a banyan tree whose shade encompasses all of us."

More than anything else, **KRISHEN KHANNA**'s views, debates and recollections have left many a young artist and art lover enriched

Khanna has stated, "All great art has to be local.... At the same time, great art transcends the ordinary moment and strives to a moment of infinity." Nothing could be more true of the artist himself. ■

–Yashodhara Dalmia



Maestro and His Metal Clockwise from left, Subodh Gupta; 'There is always cinema', 2008; 'Portrait 1', 2015; 'Guchha', 2024

city and its people. Every person who moved here from any state was given a slang word. I was called Bihari and while most people take it offensively, I had no problem."

Among his many works, 'Gehri Neend' and 'Guchha' stand out for their concept and their names. The former translates to 'deep sleep' and implies eternal slumber through the use of a skull. The other is a stainless-steel sculpture created with spoons, forks and knives to depict a *guchha* or a bunch of flowers.

Yet again, utensils form an inherent part of this show. In Gupta's words, he has been able to create his language through these daily objects. "When I first began using them in 1999, over 90 per cent of the population had stainless steel utensils. It also holds a special meaning in my life because of my love for food and cooking. You will find me in the kitchen when not in my studio," he shares.

For Gupta, utensils also help him portray the complexity of life and the layered nature of people. "When you touch stainless steel utensils, they are cold. Sometimes, they shine bright but are also empty. *Kabhi kabhi chamak mein bhi khaalipan hota hai* [sometimes, you can be empty from within even if everything outside is glittering]," he points out. ■

–Geetika Sachdev